

Before You Click "Pay Later"

Five checks in five minutes, before a small monthly payment turns into a bill you didn't see coming.

1 What will I pay in total?

2 Roughly what yearly rate is that?

3 What happens if I'm late, or don't finish on time?

4 When does the first payment leave, and from where?

5 What else is due that month?

Plus: the free trial you started at checkout, and a one-page list to keep every plan in one place.

How to use this guide

Open it when you're about to pick a payment plan: pay-in-4, "only \$X a month", store financing, a 0% promotion. Go through the five checks. Each one takes about a minute and needs only the numbers on the checkout screen or the agreement.

What this guide is

- A way to see the full cost before you agree to it.
- Simple maths you can do on your phone's calculator.
- Questions to ask, and words to look for in the agreement.

What it isn't

- Financial, legal or tax advice. It doesn't tell you whether to use a plan.
- A review of any company. Every plan is different: your agreement is the final word.

All examples in this guide are made up. Rates are rounded estimates worked out from the payment schedule and don't include fees charged separately.

1 What will I pay in total?

The monthly price is only part of the story. Multiply it out.

$$\begin{aligned} &\text{payment} \times \text{number of payments} \\ &- \text{price} \\ &= \text{what the plan costs you} \end{aligned}$$

EXAMPLE (MADE UP)

Phone price	\$1,200
Plan: \$67 a month × 24 payments	\$1,608
Extra you pay	\$408

If the answer is **\$0**, the plan costs nothing extra as long as every payment is on time. If it's more than \$0, that difference is the price of paying later.

2 Roughly what **yearly rate** is that?

\$408 on \$1,200 doesn't sound like much until you see it as a yearly rate (APR). That's the number you can compare with a credit card or a loan.

EXAMPLE PLAN (MADE UP)	TOTAL PAID	EXTRA	ABOUT
\$279 watch, pay-in-4, first payment at checkout, no fee	\$279	\$0	0% APR
\$649 TV, 12 × \$59 a month	\$708	\$59	16.4% APR
\$499 console, 6 × \$89.50 a month	\$537	\$38	25.7% APR
\$1,200 phone, 24 × \$67 a month	\$1,608	\$408	29.8% APR

Why a short plan can have a high rate

The console plan only costs \$38 extra, but you're borrowing for six months and paying it back a little at a time, so the yearly rate comes out higher than the TV's.

Rates worked out with the RATE() spreadsheet function from price, payment and number of payments. Fees charged separately are not included. If the checkout page states an APR, use that one.

3 What if I'm **late**, or don't finish on time?

This is where "0%" can stop being 0%. Before you agree, find these two things in the agreement.

1. The late fee

Search the terms for "late fee" or "missed payment". Note the amount and when it's charged.

2. "Deferred interest" or "no interest if paid in full"

Some store cards and financing offers work like this: if any of the promotional balance is still unpaid when the promotion ends, interest can be charged going back to the day you bought it, not just on what's left. The US Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB) has warned that these charges can catch people by surprise.

Words that mean **look closer**: *deferred interest, no interest if paid in full*.

Words that usually mean **no back-dated interest**: *0% APR* for a set period, where interest only starts on what's left afterwards. Always confirm in your own agreement.

Source: CFPB, "How to understand special promotional financing offers on credit cards" and CFPB press release on retail card promotions (checked October 3, 2026). Links on page 12.

4 When does the **first payment** leave, and from where?

Two plans with the same price can hit your account at very different times.

At checkout, or later?

Many pay-in-4 plans take the first payment the moment you buy. Others start a month later. Write down the first date.

Which card or account?

If payments come off a debit card, make sure the money is there on each date. If they come off a credit card, the plan is now part of that card's bill too.

Autopay on or off?

Autopay helps you avoid late fees, but only if the account has enough in it. Either way, put a reminder in your phone two days before each payment.

5 What else is due that month?

One plan is easy. Four plans landing in the same month is where it hurts. Line them up.

MADE-UP EXAMPLE, JANUARY	PAYMENTS THAT MONTH	DUE
Smart watch, pay-in-4, every 2 weeks from Nov 27	1	\$69.75
Flights, pay-in-4, every 2 weeks from Dec 15	2	\$210.00
TV, \$59 a month from Dec 27	1	\$59.00
Game console, \$89.50 a month from Dec 27	1	\$89.50
January total		\$428.25

Quick way to do this

Use the list on page 10. For each plan, write the first and last payment date, then count how many payments fall in each of the next three months.

Did you also start a **free trial**?

Checkout pages, especially around sales, often bundle a free trial: shipping memberships, streaming, apps. They turn into charges on their own.

Cancel-by date = the day before it bills

- Write the cancel-by date down now, not later.
- Put a phone reminder two days before it.
- Note what it costs after the trial, and how often (monthly or yearly).
- If you decide to keep it, that's fine. Just make it a choice, not a surprise.

The 5 checks, **on one page**

☐ **Total:** payment × number of payments – price = _____

☐ **Rate:** is the extra \$0? If not, roughly what APR? (see page 4)

☐ **Late / unpaid:** late fee? "deferred interest" or "no interest if paid in full"?

☐ **First payment:** date _____ · from which card or account?

☐ **Same month:** what else is due? Added to my list on page 10?

☐ **Free trial?** Cancel-by date _____

If any box makes you pause, it's fine to close the tab and decide tomorrow. The offer will usually still be there.

My pay-later plans

ITEM	PAYMENT	HOW OFTEN	# LEFT	FIRST	LAST	TOTAL LEFT

Due in each of the next 3 months

MONTH	TOTAL DUE	MONTH	TOTAL DUE	MONTH	TOTAL DUE

Tap a box to type. On a phone, open the PDF in a PDF app (Adobe Acrobat Reader, Apple Books / Files or Google Drive) and save after filling in.

WANT IT WORKED OUT FOR YOU?

Hidden Cost Tracker

The same checks, done automatically in a Google Sheet (also works in Excel).

- Enter price, payment and number of payments: get the real APR and a HIGH / CHECK / OK flag.
- Debt-free date, payments left and interest still to pay.
- Subscriptions and free trials with next charge and cancel-by countdowns.
- One dashboard: how much of your income is already spoken for each month.

SEE HIDDEN COST TRACKER →

checkmaybe.gumroad.com/l/kofwfjf

Your copy lives in your own Google Drive. Estimates only, not financial advice.

Where this comes from

Deferred interest (page 5)

Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, "How to understand special promotional financing offers on credit cards":

www.consumerfinance.gov/archive/blog/how-understand-special-promotional-financing-offers-credit-cards/

CFPB press release, "Consumer Financial Protection Bureau Encourages Retail Credit Card Companies to Consider More Transparent Promotions":

www.consumerfinance.gov/archive/newsroom/consumer-financial-protection-bureau-encourages-retail-credit-card-companies-consider-more-transparent-promotions/

Checked October 3, 2026. Rules and offers change: read your own agreement.

The example numbers

All plans in this guide are made up. Yearly rates were worked out with the spreadsheet RATE() function from price, payment and number of payments, and rounded to one decimal. They exclude any fees charged separately.

Not advice

This guide is for general information. It is not financial, legal or tax advice and doesn't recommend for or against any payment plan or company. Free to keep and share as a whole; please don't sell it.

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